

GOV97 Syllabus

The Political Economy of Cities

Jeeyoung Lee

Version April 16, 2026 *subject to change*

Instructor: Jeeyoung Lee

Class Time: Mondays 3:00–5:00

Class Location: Sever 215

Office Hours: Mondays 5:00–6:00 and Wednesday 3:00–4:00, by appointment

Calendly (office hours): <https://calendly.com/jeeyounglee-book/officehours>

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This course explores contemporary urban politics and urban policy issues from a comparative perspective. 80% of the population in developed countries live in cities, making cities the center of economic and social activity. Despite mounting demand to move into cities, many struggle to provide affordable housing, public transit, clean air and water, etc. The main purpose of this course is to understand how urban political theory has evolved, to critically examine its limits on explaining current urban political phenomena, to explore the politics of building infrastructure and providing public goods in democratic urban settings, and understand how urban settings have changed politically in recent years.

This is a seminar-style course. That means, there will be no lecture. *Hence, students are expected to attend all sessions and actively participate in all class discussions and activities. Students are also expected to substantively engage with the readings.*

Course Components

Course Meetings:

This course will meet once a week for 2 hours from 3pm to 5pm on Mondays. This course begins the first week. Students are expected to attend all sessions and actively participate in all class discussions and activities. Students are also expected to substantively engage with the readings.

Written Assignments:

Readings and Discussion Posts: Starting during Week 2, you must post a short reaction to the readings on the Canvas site by Sunday 12pm before class. Your post should be less than one page and should bring up one or two questions, critiques, or ideas with explicit reference to the readings assigned for that week's class. Other students in the course can see your postings. You can respond to each other but are not required to do so. While these need not make a formal argument, they should have a coherent point that is grounded in the readings; it should be evident that you have done the readings. The posts should not simply be about your personal experience or about current events, although you can tie anecdotal ideas in with a discussion about the readings. Your instructor will use your questions and critiques from the online forum in class discussion. After the first week, there are ten class meetings with assigned readings. You must post discussions for **at least nine of the ten**, but you are encouraged to post something every week in order to collect and synthesize your thoughts before class. Students will be asked about their memos by the instructor during class discussion.

Writing as a Social Scientist:

In this course, students will learn how to write like a social scientist, which is an essential part of social science research. To that end, students will write a series of short papers that will accumulate toward a work product central to social science: a research paper. The purpose of the assignments is to make you a skilled consumer of social science claims and evidence and to prepare you to undertake more social science research. Writing these papers is an interactive process and you will meet with your instructor throughout the process.

For the research prospectus, you will compose a research question that speaks to a topic covered in the course. You will then draw on literature from the course, in addition to literature from outside the course, to consider possible answers to your question. You will propose data sources and analysis to answer your question. Qualitative or quantitative research proposals are permitted.

- **Pre-Prospectus:** The pre-prospectus paper will propose a research question and review the literature related to that question. It will allow you to make a first attempt at writing a compelling introduction and will provide practice with tying a specific research question to a broader theory in the surrounding social science literature. In the pre-prospectus, you will also build from the literature to articulate preliminary hypotheses about the answer to your research question. The pre-prospectus will be 4 to 5 pages in length. You will meet with your Teaching Fellow at some point in this process, before the due date of the pre-prospectus. **You will upload the completed**

assignment by March 12th 5pm.

- **Analysis Reflection Paper:** The analysis reflection paper will allow you to explore the strengths and drawbacks of various methodological approaches to answering your proposed research question. In the reflection paper, you will propose two potential methodological approaches to answering your research question. You will identify potential data sources and describe preliminary plans for using them to generate evidence for your hypotheses. You will then discuss the limitations of each approach. This assignment will be 3 to 4 pages in length. **You will upload the completed assignment April 2nd 5pm.**
- **Prospectus:** The prospectus will be 8 to 10 pages, and will lay out your research question, review the relevant literature, describe your planned methodology to answer the question, and address any limitations with this methodology. You will essentially combine an edited version of the pre-prospectus and a portion of the analysis reflection paper to generate the prospectus. The prospectus will allow you to refine your presentation of the research question and literature review based on your TF's feedback and your growing knowledge of the topic. You will also propose a refined version of one of the methodological approaches described in your analysis reflection paper and broaden your discussion of the limitations of your chosen methodology. You will meet with your Teaching Fellow at some point in this process, before the due date of the prospectus. You will upload the completed assignment by **May 4th 5pm.**

Grading

These assignments are to be submitted via Canvas at the times noted.

Assignment	Percent of Final Grade	Due Date
Class Participation	40%	
Reading Discussion Posts	20%	
Class Participation	20%	
Research Assignments	60%	
Pre-Prospectus	10%	March 12 5pm
Analysis Reflection Paper	10%	April 2nd 5pm
Prospectus	40%	May 4th 5pm

Additional Course Policies

- **Generative AI:** The default is that such use is disallowed unless otherwise stated. It is a violation of the honor code to incorporate into your answers text, code, and

any other material produced predominantly by generative AI. The expectation is that submitted assignments are a student's own work. You may use generative AI as a conversational (like bouncing ideas with a fellow student) or contextualizing (as a Google search) tool. You may also use it for grammar correction (with a warning that writing should preserve the student's own voice). It should be noted that the output from AI tools can often contain hallucinated or incorrect assertions, and the writing from these tools is often anemic. It is each student's responsibility to assess the validity and applicability of any generative AI output that is submitted; you bear the final responsibility. Violations of this policy will be considered academic misconduct. We draw your attention to the fact that different classes at Harvard could implement different AI policies, and it is the student's responsibility to conform to expectations for each course.

- **Attendance Policy:** Students are expected to attend all classes. Appropriate excuses for missing class (e.g., health or family emergencies) will be permitted with documentation from HUHS or your Residential Dean.
- **Late Assignments:** Assignments turned in after the due date will receive a penalty of one letter grade by one day. Grace period for late assignments are 15 minutes. For example, an 'A' grade is reduced to an 'A-' if an assignment is submitted within 24 hours after the due date. In the extraordinary event of an unforeseen and unavoidable circumstance that prevents you from turning in an assignment on time, you must provide documentation.
- **Extensions:** I will consider assignment extensions only in extraordinary circumstances, such as personal, family or medical emergencies. I am most likely to approve an extension request if you provide appropriate documentation (e.g., HUHS note) and make the request in a timely fashion (i.e., a few days before the due date). Extension requests 24 hours before the due date will not be considered. Without an extension, the assignment will be considered late and grades will be deducted as a late submission.
- **Technology Policy:** You may use a tablet or laptop in seminar meetings to take notes and refer to readings, though please stay focused— stay away from email and social media. The use of phones are not allowed in class.
- **Office Hours:** I will host office hours on [TBD] at the Center for European Studies. Office hours is the perfect place for you to discuss class concepts further, discuss your research progress, raise any concerns you have about the course, or chat about your studies, more generally. My office hours are appointment-only; you may sign-up at my link: [calendly](#). If these hours do not work for you due to an unavoidable conflict,

please feel free to send me an email to schedule an alternative time, though please note that I do not take office hours meetings after 5pm on weekdays or on weekends.

- **Collaboration Policy:** The exchange of ideas is essential to strong academic research. You may find it useful to share sources or discuss your thinking for any of these papers with peers, particularly if you are working on similar topics. You may even read each other's drafts and provide feedback. However, you should ensure that any written work you submit is the result of your own research and writing and that it reflects your own thinking and approach to the topic. You must be sure to cite any books, articles, websites, lectures, etc. that you draw on. Furthermore, while you may seek the advice or help of your peers, your data analysis must be performed on your own and you should consult with your Teaching Fellow to make sure you are not duplicating the analysis of any other student in your section.
- **Accessibility:** Please let me know as soon as possible and not later than the 3rd week if you are registered with the Accessible Education Office so we can work together to make any and all alterations necessary.

Schedule of Readings

The week-by-week course calendar is below. Readings associated with each week should be completed prior to the seminar meeting and (if you are assigned) upload your memo for that week. Digital copies of all course readings will be made available via Canvas. There is no requirement to purchase any of the articles or books. Additional resources are not required reading but will also be provided.

Week 1 Common Lecture (January 26)

GOV97 lecture (more information will be provided to all GOV97 students)

Week 2 Why Cities? (February 2)

There is much emphasis on globalization and along with it, a focus on bigger geographic scales that span across countries. This course focuses on cities, a relatively granular geographic scale of study. However, with 80% of the population in developed countries and increasingly more people in developing countries live in cities, cities can be argued to be the sites of globalization, center of human activity and in extension, politics. Why should we focus on cities? How do we define “urban” and “rural” and how can we draw boundaries between them for research purposes? How are urban areas different—economically and politically— from “non-urban”?

- Scott, Allen J., and Michael Storper. “The nature of cities: The scope and limits of

urban theory.” *International journal of urban and regional research* 39, no. 1 (2015): 1-15.

- Rodden, Jonathan. “The Geographic Distribution of Political Preferences.” *Annual Review of Political Science* 13, no. 1 (2010): 321-340.
- Glaeser, Edward L. “Urbanization and Its Discontents.” *Eastern Economic Journal* 46 (2020) : 191–218.

Week 3 Theories on Urban Politics (February 9)

This week covers some theories of urban politics. Mostly based on the US, these theories are foundational, but heavily criticized by its narrow focus on the US context. What makes these theories political and urban? Who are the actors (who rules the city)? How do these theories explain contemporary urban contexts? Which cities do these theories successfully explain?

- Dahl, Robert Alan. *Who Governs? Democracy and Power in an American City*. Yale Studies in Political Science. New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1989. Ch1. The Nature of the Problem, 8. Overview: The Ambiguity of Leadership
- Logan, John R., and Harvey L. Molotch. “The City as a Growth Machine.” In *Urban Fortunes: The Political Economy of Place*, 20th anniversary ed., with a new preface, Chapter 3 The City as A Growth Machine. Berkeley: University of California Press, 2007.
- Freemark, Yonah, Justin Steil, and Kathleen Thelen. “Varieties of Urbanism: A Comparative View of Inequality and the Dual Dimensions of Metropolitan Fragmentation.” *Politics & Society* 48, no. 2 (2020): 235–274

Additional Reading

- Peterson, Paul E. *City limits*. University of Chicago Press, 1981. Chapter 1-3, 7.
- More on the origin of elitist theory: Hunter, Floyd. *Community power structure: A study of decision makers*. UNC Press Books, 1953.
- Molotch, Harvey. “The City as a Growth Machine: Toward a Political Economy of Place.” *American Journal of Sociology* 82, no. 2 (1976): 309–32.
- John Logan and Harvey Molotch, *Urban Fortunes: The Political Economy of Place* (London: University of California Press, 1987). Chapter 1.
- Clarence Stone and Heywood T. Sanders, eds, *The Politics of Urban Development* (Lawrence: University Press of Kansas, 1987)

Week 4 (February 16) President's Day

No class

Week 5 Urban Form and Political Geography (February 23)

Who affects city policies and urban form? Why do cities look the way they look? Of course, cities grow organically— but cities are planned, states intervene in development, and national governments grant funding for (re)development. Hence urban form is affected by regimes, bureaucratic configurations, political function, ideology, beliefs about the environment, etc. But before jumping into politics, we will look at briefly the Alonso-Muth-Mills (AMM) model of the mono-centric city, the workhorse model of urban economics. This model is heavily criticized, but is still used as the benchmark of what cities should look like under no constraints of regulatory or natural land use. But many cities deviate from this model, and this week focuses on the political factors that have shaped cities.

- Nall, Clayton. "The Political Consequences of Spatial Policies: How Interstate Highways Facilitated Geographic Polarization." *The Journal of Politics* 77, no. 2 (2015): 394-406.
- Nathan, Noah L. "Explaining Urban Order: The Autocratic Origins of Africa's City Street Networks." *World Politics* 77, no. 4 (2025): 693-736.
- Xu, Alice. "The Political Origins of Slum Growth and Segregation in Cities." Available at SSRN 4517935 (2023).

Additional Readings

- Full Book: Nall, Clayton. *The road to inequality: how the federal highway program polarized america and undermined cities*. Cambridge University Press, 2018.
- Dahl, Robert Alan. *Who Governs? Democracy and Power in an American City*. Yale Studies in Political Science. New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1989. Ch10. Leaders in Urban Redevelopment

Week 6 Urban Inequality and Urban Poverty (March 2)

How should we think about urban inequality? How do we measure it? What about segregation? Why does it happen? How does inequality and segregation affect political attitudes, preferences, and outcomes?

- Glaeser, Edward L., Matthew Resseger, and Kristina Tobio. Urban Inequality. Policy brief. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Taubman Center for State and Local Government, 2009.
- Dancygier, Rafaela M., and David D. Laitin. "Immigration into Europe: Economic discrimination, violence, and public policy." *Annual Review of Political Science* 17, no. 1 (2014): 43-64.
- Buchholz, Maximilian, and Michael Storper. "Black and Latinx workers reap lower rewards than White workers from years spent working in big cities." *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 122, no. 6 (2025)
- Trounstein, Jessica. "The geography of inequality: How land use regulation produces segregation." *American Political Science Review* 114, no. 2 (2020): 443-455.

Additional Readings

- Weir M, King D. Redistribution and the Politics of Spatial Inequality in America. In: Rosenbluth FM, Weir M, eds. *Who Gets What?: The New Politics of Insecurity*. SSRN *Anxieties of Democracy*. Cambridge University Press; 2021:188-210. (This whole book is very good)
- Desmond, Matthew. *Evicted: Poverty and Profit in the American City*. Crown, 2017.
- Hwang, Jackelyn, and Robert J. Sampson. "Divergent Pathways of Gentrification: Racial Inequality and the Social Order of Renewal in Chicago Neighborhoods." *American Sociological Review* 79, no. 4 (2014): 726-751.

Week 7 Local Governance and Institutions (March 9)

How do political institutions affect policy outcomes? In this week, we focus on institutions. What are institutions? Which institutions matter for urban policies and how do they matter? How does the configuration of local elections and local government affect policy outcomes? How does partisanship of the city council or the mayor affect outcomes?

- Hankinson, Michael, and Asya Magazinnik. "The supply-equity trade-off: The effect of spatial representation on the local housing supply." *The Journal of Politics* 85, no. 3 (2023): 1033-1047.
- Holland, Alisha C. "Forbearance." *American political science review* 110, no. 2 (2016): 232-246.

- Tricaud, Clemence. “Better alone? Evidence on the costs of intermunicipal cooperation.” *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics* 17, no. 1 (2025): 160-207.
- Trounstein, Jessica. “Representation and Accountability in Cities.” *Annual Review of Political Science* 13, no. 1 (2010): 407-423.

Additional Reading

- Enright, Theresa. *The making of Grand Paris: Metropolitan urbanism in the twenty-first century*. MIT Press, 2016. Ch. 5, 6
- Grumbach, Jacob M., Robert Mickey, and Daniel Ziblatt. “The insulation of local governance from black electoral power: Northern cities and the great migration.” available at: [Link to a PDF of the cited article](#) (2024).

Week 8 Spring Break March 14-22

Week 9 Local Governance and Political Behavior (March 23)

In the previous week, we explored how institutions affect political outcomes. In democratic settings, voters affect outcomes. Who shows up to vote? Again, (going back to Dahl from Week 2) who rules the city? How does public opinion affect public policy?

- Aldrich, John H. “Rational choice and turnout.” *American journal of political science* (1993): 246-252.
- Hirschman, Albert O. *Exit, voice, and loyalty: Responses to decline in firms, organizations, and states*. Harvard university press, 1972. Chapter 1.
- Einstein, Katherine Levine, Maxwell Palmer, and David M. Glick. “Who participates in local government? Evidence from meeting minutes.” *Perspectives on politics* 17, no. 1 (2019): 28-46.
- Hall, Andrew B., and Jesse Yoder. “Does homeownership influence political behavior? Evidence from administrative data.” *The Journal of Politics* 84, no. 1 (2022): 351-366.
- de Benedictis-Kessner, Justin, and Michael Hankinson. “Concentrated burdens: How self-interest and partisanship shape opinion on opioid treatment policy.” *American Political Science Review* 113, no. 4 (2019): 1078-1084.

Week 10 Politics of Housing (March 30)

This week covers the political economy of housing. Research on housing has not focused on urban areas, despite housing politics manifesting most intensely in cities. How do people think about property, housing, residential location? How does property rights affect investment incentives? How does housing (or lack thereof) affect politics? How does the financialization of housing affect policy preferences?

- Ansell, Ben W. “The politics of housing.” *Annual review of political science* 22, no. 1 (2019): 165-185.
- Hankinson, Michael. “When do renters behave like homeowners? High rent, price anxiety, and NIMBYism.” *American Political Science review* 112, no. 3 (2018): 473-493.
- Enos, Ryan D. “What the demolition of public housing teaches us about the impact of racial threat on political behavior.” *American Journal of Political Science* 60, no. 1 (2016): 123-142.
- Chou, Winston, and Rafaela Dancygier. “Why parties displace their voters: Gentrification, coalitional change, and the demise of public housing.” *American political science review* 115, no. 2 (2021): 429-449.
- Hankinson, Michael, Asya Magazinnik, and Melissa Sands. “The Policy Adjacent: How Affordable Housing Generates Policy Feedback Among Neighboring Residents.” *SocArXiv*. August 20 (2022).

Additional Reading

- Dancygier, Rafaela, and Andreas Wiedemann. “The financialization of housing and its political consequences.” *American journal of political science* 69, no. 4 (2025): 1354-1373.
- Ryan-Collins, Josh, Toby Lloyd, and Laurie Macfarlane. *Rethinking the economics of land and housing*. Bloomsbury Publishing, 2017. Ch. 3, 4, 5
- Enos, Ryan D. “Causal effect of intergroup contact on exclusionary attitudes.” *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 111, no. 10 (2014): 3699-3704.

Week 11 Local Services and Public Goods (April 6)

What are public goods? How did the state become involved in providing public goods and services? How does the shape of the city, its level of segregation, its electoral rules, etc. affect provision of public goods and services?

- Min, Brian. *Power and the vote: Elections and electricity in the developing world*. Cambridge University Press, 2015. p. 1-13.
- Ansell, Ben W., and Johannes Lindvall. *Inward conquest: The political origins of modern public services*. Cambridge University Press, 2020. Chapter 1, 2
- Holland, Alisha C. "Making the public work: geography, externalities, and preferences for mass transit." *British Journal of Political Science* 53, no. 3 (2023): 1041-1060.
- Xu, Alice Z. "Segregation and the spatial externalities of inequality: A theory of interdependence and public goods in cities." *American Political Science Review* 118, no. 3 (2024): 1431-1448.
- Trounstein, Jessica. "Segregation and Inequality in Public Goods." *American Journal of Political Science* 60, no. 3 (2016): 709-725.

Additional Readings

- Enright, Theresa. *The making of Grand Paris: Metropolitan urbanism in the twenty-first century*. MIT Press, 2016.

Week 12 Climate Change and Green Policies (April 13)

In order for cities to grow, they must reduce urban bads such as pollution and congestion, and produce enough public goods and amenities. As climate change becomes increasingly more of a concern, especially in cities that produce much pollution but also consume the most energy, policies to reduce pollution and congestion have been heavily contested. We've explored institutional approaches, and theories based on self-interest. In this week, along with long-term policy planning, we also explore civil society and how it can affect policy outcomes.

- Jacobs, Alan M. "Policy making for the long term in advanced democracies." *Annual Review of Political Science* 19, no. 1 (2016): 433-454.
- Putnam, Robert D. "Bowling alone: America's declining social capital." In *Culture and politics: A reader*, pp. 223-234. New York: Palgrave Macmillan US, 2000.

- Aldrich, Daniel P. *Site fights: Divisive facilities and civil society in Japan and the West*. Cornell University Press, 2016. Introduction and Chapter 1 (p.1-49)
- Stokes, Leah C. “Electoral backlash against climate policy: A natural experiment on retrospective voting and local resistance to public policy.” *American Journal of Political Science* 60, no. 4 (2016): 958-974.

Additional Reading

- Stokes, Leah C. 2020. *Short-Circuiting Policy: interest groups and the Battle over Clean Energy and Climate Policy in American States* (NY: Oxford University Press). chapters 1 and 9.

Week 13 Knowledge Economy, Globalization (April 20)

How has economic change and globalization affected cities, the interaction people have within cities, and political attitudes? How do the effects of common changes such as increase in immigration and the rise of the knowledge economy differ by institutions?

- Brown, Trevor E., and Suzanne Mettler. “Sequential Polarization: The Development of the Rural–Urban Political Divide, 1976–2020.” *Perspectives on Politics* 22, no. 3 (2024): 630–658.
- Ansell, Ben, and Jane Gingrich. “Concentration and Commodification.” In *The American Political Economy*, edited by Jacob S. Hacker, Alex HertelFernandez, Paul Pierson and Kathleen Thelen. New York: Cambridge University Press, 2022.
- Gingrich, Jane. “Regional Inequality and the Knowledge Economy: North America and Europe.” *Journal of European Social Policy* 35, no. 3 (2025).
- Chiopris, Caterina, Torben Iversen, and David Soskice. *The Politics of Region-Biased Technological Change*. Working paper.

Additional Readings

- Walsh, Katherine Cramer. “Putting Inequality in Its Place: Rural Consciousness and the Power of Perspective.” *American Political Science Review* 106, no. 3 (2012): 517–32.
- Huijsmans, Twan, and Jonathan Rodden. 2024. “The Great Global Divider? A Comparison of Urban–Rural Partisan Polarization in Western Democracies.” *Comparative Political Studies* 58, no. 2: 261–290.

Week 14 Globalization and Immigration (April 26)

- Hopkins, Daniel J. "Politicized places: Explaining where and when immigrants provoke local opposition." *American political science review* 104, no. 1 (2010): 40-60.
- Dias, Megan. "Cities Creating Citizens? The Impact of Local Programs Promoting Naturalization in the United States." (*RR at Policy Studies Journal*)
- Maxwell, Rahsaan. "Cosmopolitan Immigration Attitudes in Large European Cities: Contextual or Compositional Effects?" *American Political Science Review* 113, no.2: 456-474.